

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Epiphany 6
The Light of Releasing
8 February 2026



Joaquín Sorolla y Bastida - Sewing the Sail, 1896

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Grand Choeur
Sheep May Safely Graze
Communion
Sour Monique
Fuga
Gymnopedie
Toccata

John West, Guest Organist

ALFRED HOLLINS
JS BACH, arr. VIRGIL FOX
RICHARD PURVIS
FRANCOIS COUPERIN
FELIX MENDELSSOHN
ERIC SATIE
JOHN WEAVER

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Jen Almiron & Rev. Lehman

We have gathered together,
turned our hearts to praise,
willed that we might be moved
to live out the wholeness of love
in this broken world.

We have seen the places in this world
where the living of that wholeness is so needed.
Yet we cannot stop there.
We cannot pretend that to gather,
be moved,
notice pain and injustice,
is anywhere near enough.

We must push ourselves further –
push to know the completeness
of love in our own lives,
push to recognize what it means,
push to work miracles in its name.

*We say this as those
who long to walk as Jesus
and every other justice-seeking revolutionary
has only ever walked:
to change the world!*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Womb of Life and Source of Being

ODE TO JOY

Womb of life, and source of being, home of every restless heart,
In your arms the worlds awakened; you have loved us from the start.
We, your children, gather 'round you, at the table you prepare.
Sharing stories, tears, and laughter, we are nurtured by your care.

Word in flesh, our brother Jesus, born to bring us second birth,
You have come to stand beside us, knowing weakness, knowing earth.
Priest who shares our human struggles, Life of Life, and Death of Death,
Risen Christ, come stand among us, send the Spirit by your breath.

Brooding Spirit, move among us; be our partner, be our friend.
When our memory fails remind us whose we are, what we intend.
Labor with us, aid the birthing of the new world yet to be,
Free of servant, lord, and master, free for love and unity.

Mother, Brother, Holy Partner; Father, Spirit, Only One:
We would praise your name forever, One-in-three, and Three-in-one.
We would share your life your passion, share your word of world made new,
Ever singing, ever praising, one with all and one with you.

[Lyrics by Ruth Duck]

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Lehman

Holy One, each week as we gather,
we seek simply to open our hearts to you.

This day, we have come to this sacred place
seeking once again to know that holiness,
to feel it and come to understand it more fully.

Help us in these moments, to not fail in our quest
for we know we are called to speak of the presence of the sacred,
to tell of its beauty,
and to live the fullness of its grace and love
in this desperate world.

And so, O God, we must find it,
we must come to know it,
we must feel it deeply enough to share,
that it may pour, full and rich,
from our hearts, into a world so in need.

Help us this day, and in all the days to come -
to live as the light of Christ.

*From the depths of our common love we pray.
Amen and Amen.*

***Introit**

"Walk In Beauty, Walk In Light"
Cathedral Choir, Molly Pease, *Soloist*

JUDY A. ROSE

***The Lord's Prayer**

Jen Almiron

*Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever. Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

Ever just beyond our reach,
the sacred calls us to new understandings of ourselves
and to new ways of embracing the world.
Ever in pursuit of us,
it challenges us to name each place we find,
each corner in which we think ourselves alone, 'Holy.'
Ever within us,
it fills us to overflowing with a great love
so that,
ever amongst us,
it might be made known in this challenging world.

This morning, may the Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition *Ephesians 3:14-21*

Jen Almiron

These are the Words of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer
Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Tender-hearted God, we pause on this day
to remember the world that forged the path
on which we place our feet,
even as we lean into the hopes
and blank canvases of tomorrow.

*Equip us with patience as we view
the landscape of our lives
and continue to plot our course
for this year.*

Empower us, O God, with wisdom,
as we respond to the challenges
that rise up before us.

*Embolden us to speak truth
where distortions litter the way
around us.*

Comfort us when we are wearied by the world
and need shelter from its barbs.
Heal us when the wounds we receive limit and hinder us.
Delight with us when there is cause for celebration.
Implant in us a hunger for your justice.

*Anchor in us a longing for your love.
Inspire us to spread the colors of your
glorious palette throughout the lives
that intersect with ours.*

Temper our anger with discernment,
and redirect our egos away from
self-serving decisions.

*And in all things, O God,
ground us in the light and love and joy
that is your being, that we may set forth
into these days with confidence and conviction,
rejoicing in the glory that
you are for all of us.*

This morning, may it be so.
*May it be so for all of us, O God.
Amen and Amen.*

Meditation Anthem

“Ride On, King Jesus”
Brandon Harris, Solo, John West, Piano

HALL JOHNSON

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Lehman & Rev. Fregin

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

With our eyes wide open, we come to this table,
knowing the realities of our world.
We live in a time and place
where anger is honed to a painful edge,
where fear too often reigns,
and shards of broken trust are used as weapons,
rending into tatters relationships once built on love.

In this too-fragile world,
we look for ways to strengthen love
in all our relationships,
to live in ways that lift each other's souls,
and build, for every single human being,
a place that they might know
the beauty of being celebrated for who they are.

At this table we break bread, share stories, build new and
hope-filled memories as we let go of the hurts and heartaches
of other times and other tables.

At this table we fill ourselves up with the things of love
that we might live strong and confident
in the places we hold in this world.

As those who hold a vision of a love-filled world,
we break this bread as Jesus did,
and we eat together knowing it is the bread of new life.

We also pour and share a cup as Jesus did,
because we want others to come and drink
this cup of hope along with us.

Prayer of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

Holy One, you remind us again and again,
that no matter who we are, or where we are on life's journey,
we are welcome at this table -
filled with its symbols of your Creative and Divine Presence.

This morning, we come to this table with open hearts
and in the company of all, who through the ages,
have sought to live out, following the Way of Jesus.

Let us feel your love, in this sacred time and place,
as we come to celebrate our life together -
and to share these life-giving symbols.

Amen and Amen.

[adapt/jstinson]

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Lehman

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Hallelujah"

G. F. HANDEL, arr. MERVYN WARREN,
MICHAEL O. JACKSON, & MARK KIBBLE

Cathedral Choir, Christin Byrdsong, *Conductor*

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Jen Almiron

Holy One,
during this continued season of Epiphany,
we remember the light of your love.
At the heart of this incarnation is your presence
and light and your willingness to take on flesh,
bone and breath.

*In the days to come,
help us to affirm
the material that we are made of.
And, help us to remember, O God,
that you are not distant or detached or indifferent,
but you are with us in each and every moment,
of our lives and beyond.*

*May we always remember – and claim -
your love.
Amen and Amen.*

Please be seated

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

Love all Creation
The whole of it and every grain of sand
Love every leaf
Every ray of God's light
Love the animals
Love the plants
Love everything
If you love everything
You will perceive
The divine mystery in things
And once you have perceived it
You will begin to comprehend it ceaselessly
More and more everyday
And you will at last come to love the whole world
With an abiding universal love.

-Fyodor Dostoyevsky

May it ever be so.

May it ever be so for all of us.

Amen and Amen!

Choral Response

"City Called Heaven"
Cathedral Choir, Christin Byrdsong, *Soloist*

JOSEPHINE POELINITZ

*Hymn for the Journey

Come, See the Fullness

BUNESSAN

God the Creator, gave in abundance
All of the wonder we now behold;
Colors of glory, everyday beauty,
Echo the story of God's deep love.

Bold as the sunlight, tender as nightfall,
Love shaped the heav'n's height; love filled the seas.
Love formed the flowers, called for the living;
Marked out the hours of time to be.

Come, see the fullness – Life we've been given;
Beauty and promise, myst'r'y and hope.
Laughter and weeping, vision and purpose;
Friends for the keeping, strength for the road.

Open our hearts wide, teach us your wisdom
Lest our days pass by empty and small.
May we be witness with your creation –
To your great kindness given to all.

-lyrics by Peggy Haymes

Carillon Sortie
HENRI MULET**Inside The Music**

"In 1992, Mervyn Warren and Quincy Jones set out to produce a love letter to the 250th anniversary of Handel's "Messiah." When they were finished, "Handel's Messiah: A Soulful Celebration" featuring, among others, Chaka Khan, Stevie Wonder, Take 6, Gladys Knight, Tramaine Hawkins, and The Clark Sisters, had infused the world with a new understanding of style blending, and taken the Grammys and the classical world by storm. It took a few decades for all "Messiah" lovers to hear the poetry of their new approach to the music. People don't typically warm to changes in their beloved art quickly. Yet, when I heard it performed live with the Denver Symphony in 2006, the crowd was fully enmeshed in the project and loved every second of it. This week we'll perform their setting of the title track of Handel's massive oratorio, the "Hallelujah Chorus." What Warren et al did to bring this icon to new life through centuries of black American music traditions feels as inspired as the original. The gospel language of their translation fits like a glove into Handel's heaven-opening call for praise. Gospel music holds a special place in music history. American music rit large would not be what it is without Gospel. Some genres like Rock n Roll and RnB track so closely to Gospel that musically they share most of the same DNA. All Americans have a developed ear for the sounds of Gospel music. Yet, with that familiarity comes an easy overlooking of the people that gave rise to Gospel music and still nurture it today. Importantly, to sing in a Gospel style is not synonymous with the full Gospel tradition that surrounds those musical stylings. When Warren, Jones, and the rest created "Messiah: A Soulful Celebration," they weren't simply changing notes, rhythms, and timbre. They were infusing beloved music with new life traditions. They were weaving the cloth of their ancestors into the larger cultural fabric that "Messiah" had grown to include. They were giving Handel's legacy new permission to speak for the justice that they had devoted their lives to forwarding. Gospel music breathes the air of the people who gave it life. To hope to understand the music requires a humility to listen and create space for understanding the people who know it in their bones. To be moved by its artistic expression and spiritual depths represents but the first step in that exploration. We are fortunate to have two leaders who were nurtured by this music and its surrounding traditions from a young age in addition to the nurturing they experienced in Western classical music. I'm grateful that John is here to share his industry knowledge and history with the piece. Special thanks as well to Christin for his inspiration to bring this glorious music into our space." ~ Dr. David Harris